

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 1
Painting the Stars ~ A Renaissance of Wonder
6 September 2026

LVF Update Saturday 5:30pm

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML & tbd

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and ... center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Words of Gathering

We gather now,
harvesters of an all-pervasive grace,
unexpected benefactors of the deed
to this great and glorious cosmic inheritance.

We, the walking, waking stars, ablaze with
wonder,
imagination,
and hope,
gather to remember three words: *kinship* with all
that is;
debt, that can only be paid forward; *gift*, sacred
mantra of the humble.

Creation,
the great and glorious sacrifice of abundance, asks
in return-
only-
that we shed our entitled egos
and drop to our knees,
uttering a single, simple prayer
that changes everything:
'Thank you.' [bsaguin]

Please stand as you are able in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Creation and remain standing...

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.

***Hymn of Creation**

SALZBURG

OR St. George's Windsor – OR we can use - [Come Ye Thankful People, Come.](#)

Let the whole creation cry, "Glory be to God on high!"
Heaven and earth, awake and sing, to your God your praises bring.
Sun and moon, uplift your voice, night and stars, in God rejoice;
sunshine, darkness, cloud, and storm, rain and snow in praise perform.

Chant in honor, ocean fair; earth, soft rushing through the air;
birds, with morn and dew elate, sing with joy at heaven's gate.
Let the blossoms of the earth join the universal mirth;
men and women, young and old, raise the anthem manifold.

You to whom the arts belong, add your voices to the song;
bards of knowledge and of law, to the glorious circle draw.
From the north to southern pole let the mighty chorus roll:
"Holy, holy, holy," cry; "Glory be to God on high!"

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

ML

Holy One,
sometimes we forget
that we carry around
in our bodies,
and in our luminous minds,
the entire universe.

Illumed One,
despite knowing that each carbon atom
in our blood and firing neuron in our brain
came from ancient stars,
we still ignore our own radiance.

Too often, Mysterious One,
we cannot see the miracles
that are right before our eyes.

*Help us, O God, in this time
to see your light shining upon us
and help us God to look to the stars
so that we might see your light around us,
among us, and within us -
on this day,
and on all the days to come.
Amen and Amen!*

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit**

[to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

Let us now join our voices in this Lord's Prayer...

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael to center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, may we know the harmony of heaven
in the relationships of earth
and may we know the expanse of its mystery
within ourselves and within each other.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[to lectern]

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

from the Psalms Psalm 19:1-4

A Reading from the Psalms...

The heavens herald your glory, O God,
and the skies display your handiwork.
Day after day they tell their story,
and night after night they reveal
the depth of their understanding.
Without speech, without words,
without even an audible voice,
their cry echoes through all the world,
and their message reaches the ends of the earth.

from the Prayer of Azariah

And please join us in this reading from the Prayer of Azariah...

**Blessed are you in the high heavens, O God.*

Let the sun and moon praise you.

Let the stars and all that shines with glory praise you.

For you are the God of all creation.

This is the witness of the people.

Thanks be to God.

*The Prayer of Azariah is a passage that appears after [Daniel 3:23](#) in [Roman Catholic](#) and [Eastern Orthodox](#) Bibles, as well as in the ancient Greek [Septuagint](#) translation.

[Christoph short transition ML center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

[Christoph transition out of silence as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

[Michael center chancel when all are seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to the presence of Who We Are in this place.

Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope, or despair,
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow
and with these things we paint the skies above us.

May the beauty of life's fullness unfold in our hearts
that we may loosen
the grip of the mundane on our lives.
May the richness of mystery unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for proof.
May the possibility of newness and light
be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith
and soar as into a world changed by our possibilities.

May we see in the skies we have painted
the collective beauty of the world
and the miracle of our presence in it.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Ame!

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

A Renaissance of Wonder

LVF

[Christoph transition ... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

FOOD AT FIRST QR Code

Offertory Anthem

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[... to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Prayer of Offering**

O God, of the Universe,
we give thanks today
for the Driving Force
at work in our world
that becomes visible
in extravagant generosity
and celebration of being.

We rejoice in the awareness
that we are co-creators with you
of this life
and we pray for the grace
to accept its responsibilities.

*Help us in these days to work with
the Spirit of Life so that we may
give breath to your dream
for our lives, and for our world.
We pray this in the Way of of the One
who taught us how to see.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

Words of Blessing

LVF

The blessings of heaven,
the blessings of the earth,
the blessings of sea and sky.
On those we love this day
and on every human family
the gifts of heaven,
the gifts of earth,
the gifts of sea and sky.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, myst'ry and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

- lyrics by Peggy A. Haymnes

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music